recognize the authority of non-Indian science, remained for centuries willfully ignorant of its competitors'. This changed after Persian culture and language began spreading in India.[22])

'The Brahmins recite the Veda without understanding its meaning,' writes Alberuni. 'Only few of them learn its explanation, and still less is the number of those who master [it well enough] to hold a theological disputation.' They don't 'allow the Veda to be committed to writing' because it must be 'recited according to certain modulations'. They teach it to the Kshatriyas, but the Vaishyas, Shudras and the outcastes 'are not allowed to hear it, much less to pronounce and recite it. If such a thing can be proved against one of them, the Brahmins drag him before the magistrate, and he is punished by having his tongue cut off'. The Brahmins maintain that 'certain passages in the Veda . . . must not be recited within dwellings, since they fear that they would cause an abortion both to women and the cattle. Therefore, they step out into the open field to recite them. There is hardly a single verse free from such and similar minatory injunctions', writes Alberuni, before providing an overview of each of the four Vedas and how they are recited. The *Samaveda*, for instance, 'treats of the sacrifices, commandments, and prohibitions. It is recited in a tone like a chant, and hence its name is derived, because *sâman* means *the sweetness of recitation*'. He goes on to explain the 'cause of this kind of recital' by relating a mythological story behind it.

The four-fold varna system made a deep impression on Alberuni. He notes that members of each varna are forbidden to dine with members of other varnas. Below them are 'people called *Antyaja*, who render various kinds of services' and live outside the towns and villages of the four varnas. Then there are people called Hadi, Doma, Chandala and Badhatau, who 'are not reckoned amongst any caste [and] are occupied with dirty work, like the cleansing of the villages and other services . . . In fact, they are considered like illegitimate children; for according to general opinion they descend from a Shudra father and a Brahmin mother as the children of fornication; therefore, they are degraded outcasts'.

Alberuni quotes Krishna from the Bhagavad Gita as affirming this varna order: 'If anybody wants to quit the works and duties of his caste and adopt those of another caste, even if it would bring a certain honour to the latter, it